By the time the team returned from the West Indies and were ready to go to Sri Lanka for three ODIs in August, I had recovered enough to join them, though throwing was still a bit of an issue. Disappointingly, the Sri Lanka series was a washout – only twenty-two balls were bowled in the first game because of rain and the second and third games were abandoned completely – although it did at least allow me more time to recover. Frustrated because of all the rain, we ended up sitting out on the hotel-room balcony playing carrom.

The next tournament was a tri-series in Malaysia in September 2006 against Australia and the West Indies, and I was delighted to score a big hundred in the first game of the competition against the West Indies. My innings of 141 not out finally put all my injury concerns to rest, though it was disappointing to lose the rain-shortened match by the Duckworth-Lewis method.

Heartened by my successful comeback, I kept promising my team-mates that I would get them a run-out in the tournament. I said that all the opposition players were aware of my injuries and were bound to take some risks against me, assuming I wouldn't be able to throw hard. It happened exactly as I had predicted and I got Australia's Damien Martyn run out when he took on my arm while fielding at third man. I celebrated by sprinting back to the wicket and my team-mates were delighted that I had kept my promise. I was back.

Australia in India 2004 – The Border-Gavaskar Trophy

1st Test. Bangalore. 6–10 October 2004

Australia 474 (MJ Clarke 151, AC Gilchrist 104, SM Katich 81, JL Langer 52; H Singh 5–146, A Kumble 3–157) and 228 (DR Martyn 45, SM Katich 39; H Singh 6–78)

India 246 (PA Patel 46, SC Ganguly 45; GD McGrath 4–55) and 239 (R Dravid 60, IK Pathan 55; JN Gillespie 3–33)

Australia won by 217 runs

2nd Test. Chennai. 14–18 October 2004

Australia 235 (JL Langer 71, ML Hayden 58; A Kumble 7–48) and 369 (DR Martyn 104, AC Gilchrist 49; A Kumble 6–133, H Singh 3–108)

India 376 (V Sehwag 155, M Kaif 64, PA Patel 54; SK Warne 6–125, JN Gillespie 2–70) and 19–0

Match drawn